case, the possibility of future proliferation is extremely worrisome. Thus we agree that it is possible to overstate the nature of our theoretical disagreement, which can be reduced to a difference in the importance that we assign to crisis outcome versus process. Nonetheless, that difference remains important and leads us to very different views of proliferation's effects in South Asia and its likely implications for future nuclear powers.

Below, we shift our discussion to another pressing South Asian nuclear issue: missile defense.

MISSILE DEFENSE IN SOUTH ASIA: A DANGEROUS PROPOSITION

Despite its strong historical opposition to ballistic missile defense, the Indian government has recently become interested in acquiring missile defense capabilities. This interest can be traced to the Bush administration's decision to abandon the U.S. commitment to the 1972 Anti-Ballistic Missile Treaty. In a remarkable shift, India became one of the first states cautiously to embrace the administration's policy.[1] Since then India has undertaken small but significant steps toward the acquisition of a BMD capability, exploring possible acquisition of Israeli, Russian, and most recently American missile defense technology.[2] It has also engaged in domestic efforts to develop BMD, apparently meeting with some degree of success.[3] Indian officials have been vocal in their advocacy of missile defense. According to Indian president A. P. J. Kalam, "In the next two decades, anti-ballistic missile defense systems are going to be a major force . . . to guard against nuclear weapons attack."[4] India's chief military scientist, V. K. Saraswat of the Defence Research and Development Organisation, argues that "if I keep quiet and wait for [a missile] to fall on my city . . . a lot of damage is done. It is essential you have a system which will first take on that kind of threat."[5] Despite the efforts under way, India is not yet close to acquiring and deploying a viable ballistic missile defense program.[6]

Some analysts have written sympathetically of India's new interest in missile defense. Ashley Tellis, for example, identifies a threefold